

the room-by-room description (make sure to send the letter certified mail), and let them know that if they don't do the walk-through with you within two weeks of receiving the info, you will assume that they have signed off on your assessment.

WHILE YOU LIVE THERE:

6. For goodness' sake, try to be clean. Get to stains before they set. Bug-bomb the apartment if you get some kind of nasty bug infestation. If you have pets, clean the place constantly, get an air filter, open the windows, and clean up any mess as soon as you find it. Nothing is more terrifying for a landlord than walking into an apartment and seeing that your 13 cats have made the place damn near unlivable.
7. If you have a problem with any part of the apartment, if something breaks from normal wear and tear, the landlord is obliged to pay for it. If they don't, and you opt to fix it yourself (I had to replace a broken toilet seat and the bathtub caulking), take a picture of the before and after and add it to your notes, including the cost of replacing the item.

Bill the landlord for the item ASAP. If the landlord tries to bilk you later, you have more evidence of what a responsible tenant you were.

WHEN YOU LEAVE:

8. Whether or not you clean the place really depends on if you already paid a nonrefundable cleaning deposit. I have never lived anywhere that didn't require me to pay a cleaning deposit. So I'll clean up anything egregious, but the rest of the place, I leave broom-clean. If you haven't already paid a nonrefundable cleaning deposit, clean the bejesus out of the place.
9. Do the whole picture thing again. Make sure that the landlord does a walk-through with you, and have them sign an agreement that you have left the apartment in fair condition. Don't feel like a jerk for doing this. You have the right to protect your money and yourself.
10. Don't assume that a super-nice landlord equals a returned security deposit. Be wary of everyone and don't let something slip just because you think the landlord really likes you.